149 Tiny Speakers, One Very Loud Wall

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What happens if you link 149 tiny speakers together? A team at WIRED found out by building a wall of sound at its London office. The speakers were IKEA's Kallsup, a $10 **Bluetooth** speaker launched in April. Each one is a small cube in white, green, or pink.

WIRED asked IKEA's **headquarters** in Almhult if it could try. IKEA agreed and sent 150 speakers. One speaker was damaged in shipping, so the team worked with 149.

Chaining them was simple. After **pairing** one speaker with an iPhone 16 Pro, the team powered on another cube while music played and held down Play until a **chime** meant "multi-speaker" mode. Linking all the speakers took about 30 minutes.

At 100 speakers, the sound was seriously loud, like a fire alarm. At maximum volume with all 149, the team could not hear each other speak and could feel **vibrations**. A wall costs $1,490, and WIRED does not recommend buying one. Its lesson was simple: for high-quality audio, buy a better speaker.

Word Treasure

Bluetooth -- A way for devices to connect and share music without a wire.
pairing -- Connecting two devices so they can work together.
chime -- A short, clear ringing sound.
vibrations -- Small, fast shakes that you can feel.
headquarters -- The main office where a company is run from.

Background you need

A Bluetooth speaker is a small speaker that plays music from a phone without a wire.

When speakers are linked together, they can all play the same music at the same time.

Adding more speakers makes the sound louder, but many small speakers do not sound as clear as one better speaker.

Break it down

WHO: A team at WIRED, with speakers sent by IKEA
WHAT: Built a wall of sound by linking many tiny speakers together
WHERE: At WIRED's London office
WHY: To find out what happens if you link many tiny speakers together

Why it matters

It helps kids see that buying more gadgets is not always better than choosing one good one.

Test what you remember

1. How many speakers did the team work with in the end?

- (A) 149
- (B) 150
- (C) 100
- (D) 10

2. Why did the team work with 149 speakers instead of 150?

- (A) One speaker was lost at the office
- (B) One speaker ran out of battery
- (C) One speaker was damaged in shipping
- (D) One speaker was too big

3. What kind of speakers were used?

- (A) IKEA's Kallsup
- (B) A large concert speaker
- (C) A phone speaker
- (D) A car speaker

4. About how long did it take to link all the speakers?

- (A) About 30 seconds
- (B) About 3 days
- (C) About 3 hours
- (D) About 30 minutes

5. What was the sound like at 100 speakers?

- (A) Very quiet
- (B) Like a whisper
- (C) Seriously loud, like a fire alarm
- (D) Completely silent

6. How much does a wall of these speakers cost?

- (A) $100
- (B) $149
- (C) $10
- (D) $1,490

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. WIRED: Does not recommend buying a wall of tiny speakers, and says that for high-quality audio, you should buy a better speaker.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):